

**The Turning Point: Understanding Why the Chinese University of Hong Kong,
Shenzhen (CUHK Shenzhen) Indonesian Students Change Majors and Strategies to
Support Early Academic Decision-Making**

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Abstract

Changing majors is one of the highest crucial decisions for students in their life. Using Social Cognitive Career Theory (SCCT) and Expectancy-Value Theory (EVC), the researcher can discover a deeper understanding of the students' stories through interviews. As a result, social influence is found to be the main factor. However, quantitative is needed for accuracy and cultural diversity is necessary.

The Turning Point: Understanding Why the Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shenzhen (CUHK Shenzhen) Indonesian Students Change Majors and Strategies to Support Early Academic Decision-Making

Introduction

Choosing major is the most important decision for students (Silver, 2023; Xu & de Silva, 2024; Wang, 2025). Unfortunately, there are still students who change majors due to some factors such as lower grades, gender gaps, lower ability, and societal pressure (Astorne-Figari & Speer, 2019). Research from Hwang (2025) expressed that about 51% of the nursing students intended to change majors, leading to big concern for students about not preparing for their future. Moreover, there is not much evidence on strategies to ensure students make accurate decisions in their first major, as most studies rely on quantitative methods that do not explore their inner complexity. Therefore, this research aims to explore students' main factors in changing major deeply through their experiences and perspectives.

Literature Review

Several factors can lead students to switch majors. Xu and de Silva (2024) mentioned that students have less information and cannot make decisions, causing them to explore various subjects. Once students explore, they decide early to switch to other majors. As a result, students need to take more major credit hours and take longer to graduate (Xu & de Silva, 2024). The same study discovered that grades do not affect the rate of major changes. However, Astorne-Figari and Speer (2019) argued that lower grades can cause a higher changing major rate. Students with lower grades tend to feel that they struggle and are incapable, especially women in STEM majors. Gender gaps and students' preferences are factors in switching majors (Astorne-Figari & Speer, 2019). Moreover, an interesting study from Wang (2025) found that social support has a big role in the students' self-efficacy that impacts the changing major decisions using Social Cognitive Career Theory (SCCT).

SCCT is a framework from Bandura's (1986) theory that is used for career development (Lent et al., 1994). Individuals make choices based on their capability to perform (self-efficacy), their thinking on consequences for their own action (outcome expectations), and their goals. These beliefs are formed through prior learning experiences and various obstacles. Surprisingly, Expectancy-Value Theory (EVC) has similar concepts to SCCT.

The EVC model was last updated by Eccles (1983), which examines young adults' development (Wigfield, 1994). The individuals' choices are shaped by their beliefs in how well they will do (expectancy) and their values. Values are divided into four parts: importance for personal identity (attainment), interests (intrinsic), usefulness for future goals (utility), and lost alternatives or sacrifice (cost).

Despite the frameworks and quantitative research, students' inner complexity has not been explored yet. Silver (2023) addressed this gap by using qualitative interviews to explore their perceptions, their interpretations, and make meaning of changing majors. Qualitative methods have been proven to be used to understand the in-depth experiences, meaning, and process (Maxwell, 2013; Oranga & Matere, 2023). An interview is the most generally used qualitative method and generates clear qualitative data (Oranga & Matere, 2023). Silver's (2023) research gives guidance for the researcher to understand the students' experiences of switching majors by exploring their internal motivations and external environments through their stories. The research questions that guided the study are:

1. What are the main internal and external factors that influence students' decisions to change their academic major?
2. What experiences or stories led them to the process of changing majors?

Methods

The method was obtained in accordance with SCCT from Lent et al. (1994) and EVC from Wigfield (1994). The model diagram represents the process of the students' stories, consisting of five phases that are grouped into three: sources (skills, knowledge, experiences); self (self-efficacy, values); and result (goals, choices, performance) (Figure 1).

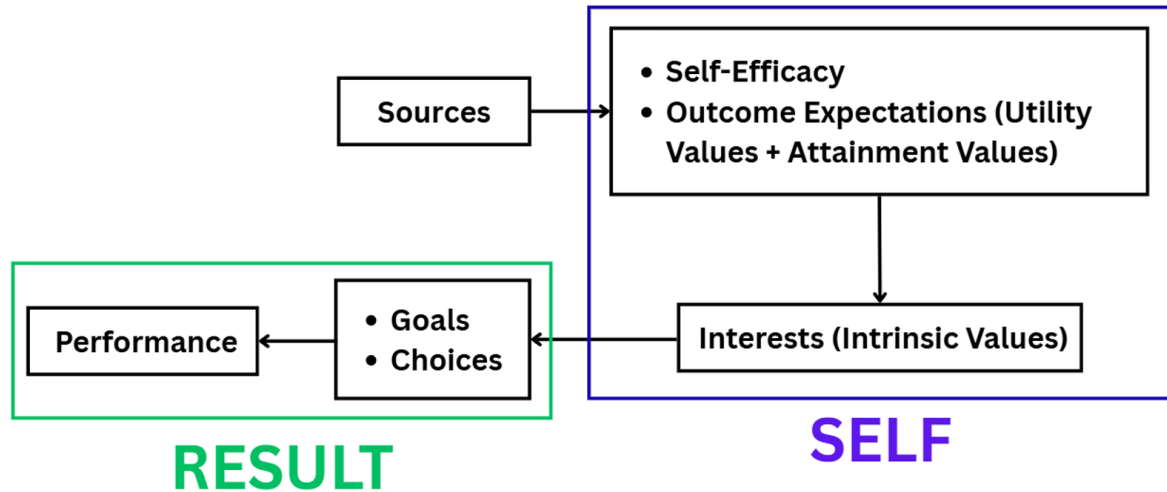


Figure 1 The model of students' story process in changing majors, combining SCCT and EVC

The participants are four Indonesian undergraduate students from CUHK Shenzhen who have changed majors once. Semi-structured interviews were used to allow participants to share their deep stories and personal reflections. To ensure comfortable and natural dialogue, interviews were conducted in English, with selective code-switching to Bahasa Indonesia as needed by the participants. All the interviews were audio-recorded and partially transcribed.

Participants were allowed to schedule the time and choose the place for the interview. To prepare participants for the interview, tools were prepared including gadgets and a microphone for the recordings. If participants chose private rooms, checking the temperature was necessary for a well-conditioned room. A pen and notebook were necessary as my guidelines during the process of the interview. The interview questions were made for each distinct phase shown in Figure 1.

Results

RQ 1: The main factors in students' decisions to change majors

Finding the patterns and connecting the data was difficult due to various factors, such as incorrect outcome expectations, grades, cost-benefit imbalance, and many more. Hence, strategies were hard to apply to support early academic decision-making. Nevertheless, social influence was found to be the main external factor influencing students' changing majors, provided that students must open their minds to the support system (influencers). The internal factors can vary as each participant had different stories, which affects the differences in sources, self, and results in Figure 1.

RQ 2: The students' experiences and stories on switching majors

Overall, the results from all the participants show that they had a problem in the self category in Figure 1. The fact that they had some issues with themselves made them want to reflect more. Afterwards, influencers (parents, friends, etc.) influenced the participants to change majors, and the participants could consider whether to follow or not. These choices could impact their result in Figure 1 to be either good or bad performance. The story patterns were quite clearly seen using Figure 1. However, several conditions required revision to improve clarity (Figure 2).

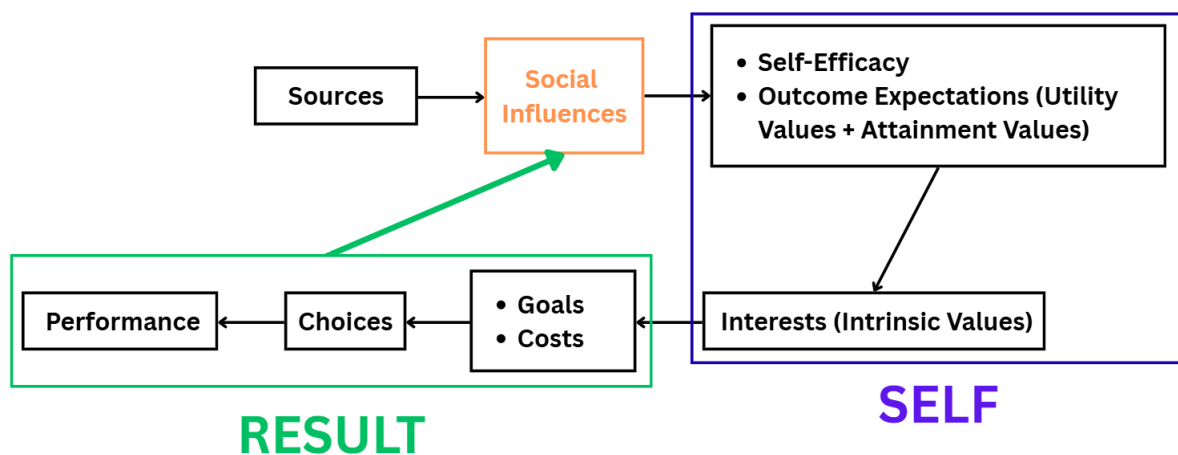


Figure 2 The revision model of students' story process in changing majors

Discussion

Previous study matches with the data presented in the Results: social support plays a hugely important role for students' self-efficacy using SCCT (Wang, 2025). While both internal and external factors varied among the participants, social influence was consistently part of the students' story process in changing majors. The social influence pattern is illustrated by the experiences of Person A, Person B, Person C, and Person D. The transcriptions are presented in Appendix C.

Person A demonstrated a clear pattern of social influence. Person A was influenced by his friend in a long conversation at night. With tired condition, Person A and his friend decided to change majors together.

Person B's answer had a few complexities in the social influence pattern, trying to show that Person B's father (influencer) indirectly influenced him by saying the GBM major was interesting. But Person B chose to refuse to be influenced by the father and stay in the first

major. Person B's decision proves that students change majors if they are not socially influenced or do not open their minds to the influencers. Unfortunately, when he made the study scheme, he realized that the electives in the study scheme were not useful. As a result, he switched to other majors.

Person C's answer gave another condition for the social influence pattern. If the influencer motivates the students not to change majors, and the students are influenced, then the students will not change majors. In this case, a friend influences Person C to stay in the first major. Person C listened to the friend's advice and, as a result, Person C regretted it, and in short, Person C changed to another major.

Person D showed a similar social influence pattern to Person A. At first, Person D felt worried due to the lack of options. But with the help of friends and environments, Person D started to feel passionate and get more interested in the new major.

The four participants' stories prove that social influence can affect students changing majors by these 2 conditions:

1. The influencers motivate the students to change majors.
2. Students open their minds to the influencers.

Other factors, including the role of grades, can also be considered; this finding contrasts with the work of Xu and de Silva (2024). Nonetheless, other factors are not consistently accurate since each student has a different story.

Generally, all the stories and experiences can be applied to the diagram in Figure 2, where all the participants talked about the skills and knowledge they had, which refer to the sources. Then, the participants get influenced by the support system, which affects their values and self-efficacy. Ultimately, this interplay of personal and social factors guided them to their result.

Conclusion

In this paper, it has been shown that social influence is the main factor in students' decisions to change majors. The story process patterns can be seen in Figure 2. Unfortunately, this research has too few subjects, lacks cultural diversity, and human complexity. Future work should prioritize (1) using quantitative and qualitative methods for accuracy and (2)

getting more findings on the process of students building their mentality and purpose for their future.

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Appendix A. Interview questions

1. Can you tell me about your original major and why you chose it?
2. What did you expect your courses and workload would be like?
3. Was anyone influential in your decision — like family, teachers, or friends?
4. When did you first start feeling that your major might not be right for you?
5. What happened around that time? Was there a specific event or course that made you realize this?
6. How did you feel during that time?
7. When you started thinking about switching, where did you look for information or help?
8. Did you talk to any academic advisors or teachers? How was that experience?
9. Did you face any difficulties understanding the process or timing?
10. Which other majors did you consider, and why?
11. What were the main reasons that pushed you to leave your old major?
12. What attracted you to your new major?
13. Did you consider any risks or costs before switching?
14. What finally convinced you to switch majors?"
15. Can you walk me through the steps you took to switch? How easy or difficult was it?
16. Who helped you the most during this time?
17. After switching, how do you feel about your new major now?
18. Looking back, what support or information do you wish you had earlier?
19. What advice would you give to first-year students who are unsure about their major?

Appendix B. Audio recording

Here's the link to hear the audio recording among the participants:

<https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/16AVzHQEy-6S78JivqGtspLcMCXJsd8vJ>

Appendix C. Social influence patterns among the participants

Person A (Change majors: Chemistry to New Energy Engineering to Finance)

Question: What finally convinced you to change majors?

Answer: It's more like the conversation that I had with my friends that time. It's like we did a conversation at night time that time and like kinda long conversation [Social Influences]. We both feel tired, we both feel like exhausted, like we can't do it anymore [Self]. So yeah we just move (majors) [Result]. And also I have a friend who moves with me.

Person B (Change majors: Data Science to Global Business Management)

Question: When did you first start feeling that your major might not be right for you?

Answer: When my father... During my second term, my father read about the Global Business Management study scheme. And then, he said it's quite interesting [Social Influences] and I can combine with finance and accounting and stuff. At first, I just like, "Nah (No), I think I am ok with Data Science." [Self] But when I try to make my study scheme during the end of second term, I realize that it's (courses and electives in the study scheme) actually not that useful for me [Result]. That's why I choose (to) change directly. More like, not suitable, not not useful. [Person B was trying to say that the first major he took is not suitable]

Person C (Change majors: Data Science to Global Business Management)

Question: Looking back, what support or information do you wish you had earlier?

Answer: Actually, at first (when) I registered to this university, I want to immediately switch Global Business Management without taking Data Science for 1 year... I wish I can know that I can normal add SME (School of Management and Economics) courses and drop some of the SDS (School of Data Science) courses in the first term...

Question: But do you think like when you take SDS Data Science... Do you actually not thinking to take Global Business Management first?

Answer: No, actually at the first term, there is like one of my friends who convince me like "Oh, at least you should try. Maybe you are more suitable in Data Science" bla bla bla [Social Influences]. And then, I listen to them [Self], but on the process, I have instant

regret...[Result]

Person D (Change majors: Data Science to Finance)

Question: When did you first start feeling that your major might not be right for you?

Answer: ... I remember I was so stressed because I remember that my grades were kinda failing, especially the biochemistry... “Hey you got 37 out of 60”. And then the I remember that the average like 50... Turns out, it wasn’t that bad cause like a lot of people got even worse. But I know that some people drop the classes, and like I was so scared... “Oh my God should I drop this class?” ... I really didn’t enjoy the subjects. I am grateful to drop the classes [Stating the stress from Person D]... I think what really helps is my friends at that moment, like a lot of them were like all of them were SME (School of Management and Economics) and that’s why I am interested, because of the environment too. They were SME and they were so passion, they were just like “just move (majors)” [Social Influences]... Quite good support system during the first moment that I wanted to move, which is very nice. But like the stressful part was definitely because of the final results, especially the fact that I ended up dropping it. I was quite worried cause like I didn’t have another option right. [Self] I mentioned that at the beginning that I want in here. I’m just like ok let me try this first and I didn’t have any other options and that’s was kind of the case. But well I kinda develop like more passion towards and interests towards what I am doing right now. [Result] So yeah it was like part of the journey...